

THE LAMB AND THE CUP

*Why the Lamb Had to Drink What We Could Not Survive — the
Bloodline of Redemption from Eden to the Throne*

“Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!”

John 1:29 (WEB)

*“My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass away from me; nevertheless, not
what I desire, but what you desire.”*

Matthew 26:39 (WEB)

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A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse in this book is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation free to read, copy, and share — and one that keeps the divine name as "**Yahweh**," which helps as we trace the God who provides the Lamb. This is a book best read slowly, with a Bible open, because its argument is made not by clever words but by the weight of the texts laid end to end.

A Note to Every Reader

There are two images that, once you see them, you cannot stop seeing — they run through the Bible from beginning to end, and they meet at a single hill outside Jerusalem. The first is a **Lamb**. The second is a **Cup**.

The Lamb tells you *who* takes your place. The Cup tells you *what* He takes from you. And the gospel, in its deepest logic, is this: **the Lamb of God drank the cup that belonged to us**.

Most people who have heard the phrase "Lamb of God" treat it as a tender bit of religious poetry. It is not poetry. It is the end of a long, blood-marked road that begins in a garden with a covering humanity could not make for itself, runs through a mountain where a father lifts a knife over his son, past a doorway painted with blood on the night of Israel's rescue, through a tabernacle of endless sacrifice, into a prophet's vision of a Servant "led like a lamb to the slaughter," and finally to a Galilean carpenter pointed out at a river — and then, at the end of all things, to a Lamb standing in the center of heaven's throne.

This book walks that road. It asks the questions most people never ask: *Why does humanity need a Lamb at all? Why does sin require blood? Why did the cup not simply pass from Jesus in the garden, if there were any other way?* The answers, taken together, are the whole gospel told through the whole Bible.

To the believer: this will make the cross enormous again. **To the skeptic:** follow the thread and judge whether it was woven by accident. **To the Jewish reader:** these are your Scriptures, the Passover and the Servant and the sacrifices, read with reverence. We compare beliefs; we never demean persons.

The Bible begins with humanity needing a covering. It ends with the Lamb upon the throne. Between those two points stands a cross. Come and follow the bloodline home.

Chapter One — The Covering We Could Not Make

Where the need for a Lamb begins

Humanity did not begin with sacrifice. It began with life, innocence, and unbroken fellowship — a garden where God walked "in the cool of the day" (Genesis 3:8) and there was nothing to hide. To understand the Lamb, you must first understand what was lost, because a Lamb is an answer, and an answer only makes sense once you feel the question.

The question is sin. Adam and Eve, given everything, reached for the one thing forbidden, and in that instant something broke that has never since been whole. The first thing they felt was not freedom but exposure: "The eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked" (Genesis 3:7). Shame had entered the world. And their first instinct is the instinct of every human heart ever since — to *cover it themselves*:

"They sewed fig leaves together, and made coverings for themselves." — Genesis 3:7 (WEB)

Fig leaves. A homemade covering, stitched in a hurry, to hide what they could not bear to have seen. It is the first religion and the oldest human project: to manage our own shame, to cover our own guilt, to make ourselves presentable by our own effort. And it does not work. When God comes, they are still hiding.

Covering now comes through death

Then God does something quiet and enormous. He replaces their inadequate covering with one of His own:

"Yahweh God made garments of animal skins for Adam and for his wife, and clothed them." — Genesis 3:21 (WEB)

The text does not pause to explain it, but the implication is impossible to miss: to clothe the man and woman in *skins*, something had to die. The first death in the Bible is not a human one; it is a creature slain so that the guilty could be covered. On the very day shame entered, a pattern was set that the rest of Scripture will deepen for thousands of years:

Humanity cannot adequately cover its own shame. God must provide the covering. And the covering comes through death.

This is the seed of everything. The fig leaves are every attempt to be good enough, religious enough, sincere enough to stand before God on our own. The garments of skin are the first whisper of the gospel: that God Himself will provide what we cannot, and that it will cost a life. The Lamb of God is the answer to a problem that began in Eden — the problem of a covering we could not make.

The first offering from the flock

The pattern advances quickly. In the very next chapter, two brothers bring offerings. Cain brings the fruit of the ground; Abel brings something else:

"Abel also brought some of the firstborn of his flock and of its fat. Yahweh respected Abel and his offering." — Genesis 4:4 (WEB)

The Bible does not yet hand us a full theology of sacrifice. But the vocabulary is gathering, word by word, like a melody being taught one note at a time: *flock, firstborn, offering, blood, acceptance, approach to God*. Already the reader is being trained to associate drawing near to a holy God with the giving of a life. Hebrews later says Abel's offering was made "by faith" (Hebrews 11:4) — he believed, somehow, that the way back to God ran through a death he did not deserve to be spared from.

The weight of the problem

Why labor this? Because everything downstream depends on taking the problem seriously. The modern world is allergic to the word *sin*; it prefers "mistakes," "brokenness," "bad choices." But the Bible insists that what is wrong with us is deeper than behavior and more serious than we want to admit. Sin is not merely the wrong things we do; it is a rupture in our relationship with the living God, a treason of the heart, and its wage — the Bible will not soften this — is death: "the wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23).

If that is the size of the problem, then no fig-leaf religion will solve it. No amount of trying harder re-stitches the garden. The covering must come from outside us, from God, and it must answer death with death. This is why the whole Bible bends toward a Lamb. We were never going to cover ourselves. The question that hangs over Eden — *who will provide the covering we cannot make?* — waits for an answer. And the next great chapter of the story gives it a name.

Chapter Two — God Will Provide the Lamb

The hardest command and the deepest promise

Generations later, God speaks to a man named Abraham words that still make readers flinch:

"Take now your son, your only son, whom you love, even Isaac, and go into the land of Moriah. Offer him there for a burnt offering." — Genesis 22:2 (WEB)

We must not rush past the horror of it, because Abraham did not. The son he had waited a lifetime for, the son of the promise, the son "whom you love" — to be offered on a mountain. Whatever else this passage is, it is the account of a father walking three days with a breaking heart. And it is, the New Testament tells us, a deliberate foreshadowing — for God Himself would one day do what He did not finally require of Abraham: offer up His only beloved Son.

Watch the details, because the Gospel writers will light every one of them: the beloved son, a mountain in the region that would become Jerusalem, and the wood for the offering laid on the son's own shoulders to carry up the hill (Genesis 22:6) — as another Son would one day carry His own cross up another hill in the same region.

"Where is the lamb?"

Then comes the question that echoes down the whole of Scripture, asked by a boy carrying firewood up a mountain:

"Isaac spoke to Abraham his father, and said, 'My father?' He said, 'Here I am, my son.' He said, 'Here is the fire and the wood, but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?'" — Genesis 22:7 (WEB)

Where is the lamb? It is one of the most important questions in the Bible, and Abraham's answer is one of the most important sentences:

"Abraham said, 'God will provide himself the lamb for a burnt offering, my son.' So they both went together." — Genesis 22:8 (WEB)

"God will provide himself the lamb." Read it slowly. Not *Abraham* will provide. Not Israel, not the temple, not human effort. **God** will provide the lamb — and the little word "himself" trembles with more meaning than Abraham could have known. The sacrifice that finally deals with sin will not be humanity's gift offered upward to God; it will be God's own provision given downward to us.

The ram and the open question

At the last second, God stops the knife and provides a substitute — but notice carefully *what* He provides:

"Abraham lifted up his eyes, and looked, and saw that behind him was a ram caught in the thicket by his horns. Abraham went and took the ram, and offered it up for a burnt offering instead of his son." — Genesis 22:13 (WEB)

A *ram* — not the lamb Abraham had spoken of. Isaac is spared; a substitute dies in his place; "instead of his son" is the gospel in three words. But the lamb Abraham prophesied is not yet here. Abraham names the place "Yahweh Will Provide," and the narrator adds a haunting note pointing to the future: "as it is said to this day, 'On Yahweh's mountain, it will be provided'" (Genesis 22:14).

So Genesis leaves an open question hanging over the whole Bible. A substitute was given on the mountain that day — but *where is the Lamb God Himself will provide?* The question is asked in Genesis 22. It will not be answered for two thousand years. Then a man will stand by a river, see Jesus walking toward him, and say seven words that finally close the loop: "Behold, the Lamb of God." The Lamb Abraham promised has arrived — provided by God, on a mountain near the very place, offered "instead of" the guilty.

Why it must be God who provides

This is the hinge of the whole book, so let it land. Every false religion runs in the same direction: humanity climbing upward, bringing its best — its rituals, its righteousness, its sincerity — hoping it is enough. The gospel runs the other way. "God will provide *himself* the lamb." Salvation is not our gift to God; it is God's gift to us. "God so loved the world, that he gave his one and only Son" (John 3:16). And because the Lamb comes from God, the cost falls on God: "God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself" (2 Corinthians 5:19). The Lamb is "of God" because God provides Him, God gives Him, and God Himself bears the cost.

The mountain of provision

There is a thread of geography here too easy to miss, and it runs the whole length of the Bible. God did not send Abraham just anywhere; He sent him to "the land of Moriah" (Genesis 22:2), to a specific mountain. And the chronicler later tells us that the temple in Jerusalem — the place of Israel's sacrifices for a thousand years — was built "on Mount Moriah" (2 Chronicles 3:1). The mountain where the substitute ram was caught in the thicket became the

mountain where the lambs were offered, morning and evening, for centuries.

And it was just outside that same city, on a hill, that the true Lamb was finally provided — for "Jesus also, that he might sanctify the people through his own blood, suffered outside of the gate" (Hebrews 13:12). The bloodline of redemption has an address. Abraham named the place "Yahweh Will Provide... On Yahweh's mountain, it will be provided" (Genesis 22:14), and on Yahweh's mountain, it was. The mountain that began as a place of provision ends, in Revelation, as the place of triumph: "I saw, and behold, the Lamb standing on Mount Zion" (Revelation 14:1). From Moriah's provision, to the temple's sacrifice, to Calvary's cross, to Zion's victory — one mountain, one Lamb, one unbroken plan.

To that bloodline we now follow the next step — to a doorway, on the night a nation was born.

Chapter Three — When I See the Blood

A lamb between judgment and the people

The defining event of the Old Testament — the one Israel would remember every single year forever — is the night they walked out of Egypt. And at the center of it is a lamb.

Israel is enslaved, and a final, terrible judgment is about to fall on the land. But God makes a way of escape, and it runs through blood. Every household is to take a lamb "without defect, a male a year old" (Exodus 12:5), kill it at twilight, and paint its blood on the doorframe. Then comes the promise that gives this book half its title:

"The blood shall be to you for a token on the houses where you are. When I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will be on you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt." — Exodus 12:13 (WEB)

Notice what saves them. Not that Israel was morally better than Egypt — they were not, and the Scriptures never pretend otherwise. They were sinners too, equally under the sentence. The single difference between the house where death passed over and the house where it struck was *the blood on the door*. A lamb died, and its blood stood between the judgment and the people. Death still came that night — it simply fell on the lamb instead of the firstborn.

The door

Here is a thread worth pausing on, because Jesus picks it up Himself. The blood was applied to the *doorway* — and to be saved, you had to be *inside*, under the blood, having entered through the marked door. Centuries later Jesus says:

"I am the door. If anyone enters in by me, he will be saved." — John 10:9 (WEB)

The doorway becomes a picture of the only entrance into safety. It is not enough to admire the lamb from the street, or to discuss the blood as an idea. The Passover demanded that you *go in* — that you place yourself, your family, your whole household, under the blood, behind the marked door. The question the Passover puts to every reader is not merely "Do you believe a lamb died?" but "Have you come inside? Are you under the blood?"

The Lamb who is our Passover

For fifteen hundred years Israel kept this feast — eating the lamb, retelling the rescue, waiting. And the New Testament announces, without hesitation, that the waiting is over:

"For indeed Christ, our Passover, has been sacrificed in our place." — 1 Corinthians 5:7 (WEB)

Christ *is* the Passover Lamb. And John's Gospel quietly notes that Jesus died at Passover, and that — like the Passover lamb, of which God commanded "they shall not break any of its bones" (Exodus 12:46) — "a bone of him will not be broken" (John 19:36). The timing was not coincidence; it was an appointment kept across fifteen centuries. The deliverance the first Passover pictured — out of slavery, through blood — was always a rehearsal for a greater one: deliverance not merely from Egypt but from sin, not merely from Pharaoh but from death itself, not for one nation but for "every tribe, language, people, and nation" (Revelation 5:9).

The lamb that never stopped dying

There is one more detail Israel lived with daily that you must feel to understand the cross. After the Exodus, God commanded a lamb to be offered *every morning and every evening*, without ceasing:

"Now this is that which you shall offer on the altar: two lambs a year old day by day continually. The one lamb you shall offer in the morning; and the other lamb you shall offer at evening." — Exodus 29:38-39 (WEB)

Every morning, another lamb. Every evening, another lamb. Day after day, year after year, century after century — a river of blood that never ran dry, because the problem it addressed was never finished. The endless repetition was itself a sermon: *these lambs cannot actually take away sin, or they would have stopped*. The daily lamb was a promissory note, renewed every dawn and dusk, waiting for a payment that would finally be marked "paid in full." It pointed, by its very ceaselessness, to the need for one Lamb, offered once, who would never need to be offered again.

Chapter Four — The Language of Sacrifice

Why blood?

If you keep reading into Leviticus, you enter what feels to modern eyes like a strange and bloody world — altars, priests, the careful handling of blood, animals slain without end. We recoil. *Why is God so concerned with blood? Is this primitive, even barbaric?* The Bible answers the question directly, and the answer is not bloodthirstiness but mercy:

"For the life of the flesh is in the blood. I have given it to you on the altar to make atonement for your souls; for it is the blood that makes atonement by reason of the life." — Leviticus 17:11 (WEB)

The point is *life*. Blood stands for life poured out. Atonement — being made "at one" with God — requires a life given in the place of the life that sin had forfeited. And do not miss the most important words in the verse: *"I have given it to you on the altar."* Even within the sacrificial system, atonement is God's gift, God's provision, God's idea. The altar is not humanity bribing an angry deity; it is God graciously providing a way for the guilty to live.

The system taught Israel a cluster of hard, unforgettable truths: that sin is serious, that God is holy, that guilt cannot simply be waved away, that life must be given for life, that the substitute must be acceptable — "without defect" — and that the worshiper needs someone to stand in his place. Every sacrifice said the same thing in blood: *the wages of sin is death, but the death may fall on another.*

The spotless offering

Run your eye over the requirement that the sacrifice be "without blemish," and you will see why no ordinary worshiper could ever be his own offering. The lamb had to be flawless precisely because it was not dying for its own faults — it had none — but for the faults of another. A blemished lamb could not bear sin; it had its own to answer for. This is why, when the New Testament reaches for words to describe the death of Jesus, it returns again and again to this exact image:

"You were redeemed... with precious blood, as of a lamb without blemish or spot, the blood of Christ." — 1 Peter 1:18-19 (WEB)

"Without blemish or spot." The sinless Lamb is the only one who can die for sinners, because He alone has no sin of His own to die for. The whole Levitical demand for an unblemished offering was a fifteen-century-long way of teaching the world that the final Sacrifice would

have to be one thing no animal and no ordinary human ever was: perfectly without sin.

The sin carried away

On Israel's holiest day, the Day of Atonement, two goats were brought before the priest (Leviticus 16). One was slain, its blood carried behind the veil to cover sin. The other — the "scapegoat" — had the people's sins confessed over its head and was then driven far out into the wilderness:

"The goat shall carry on himself all their iniquities to a solitary land." — Leviticus 16:22 (WEB)

Two animals, one atonement, two truths that one creature could not picture alone: sin must be *paid for* (the slain goat), and sin must be *carried away* (the scapegoat). Together they say that atonement both satisfies justice and *removes* the guilt — sends it away as far as the east is from the west. This is exactly the double note John strikes when he points to Jesus: "the Lamb of God, who *takes away* the sin of the world." Jesus does not merely cover sin so that God overlooks it for another year. He bears it and carries it away, finally and forever.

The sacrifice the law could not complete

And here the Old Testament confesses its own limitation, with startling honesty. For all its blood, the sacrificial system never actually finished the job:

"For it is impossible that the blood of bulls and goats should take away sins." — Hebrews 10:4 (WEB)

Impossible. The animals could *symbolize* substitution, could *teach* that sin leads to death, could *point* to a greater sacrifice — but they could not, in themselves, answer for human rebellion. An animal is not the equal of a human soul; its blood cannot pay a debt it did not incur and could never understand. So the whole system, for all its grandeur, was a vast arrow pointing beyond itself, asking a question it could not answer: *where is the sacrifice that will finally be enough?* The answer had to be greater than any lamb on any altar — a Lamb who was truly human (for humanity needed redeeming), without sin (for the offering must be spotless), willing (for He would lay down His life freely), and of infinite worth (for the debt was infinite).

The altar that pointed beyond itself

Consider the altar itself, and what its very design confessed. The altar was where the life was given and the blood was poured — the meeting place of a holy God and a guilty people. But the altar had a built-in admission of failure: the fire never went out and the sacrifices never stopped, because no offering laid on it ever ended the need for the next one. The book of Hebrews seizes on exactly this:

"Every priest indeed stands day by day serving and often offering the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins, but he, when he had offered one sacrifice for sins forever, sat down on the right hand of God." — Hebrews 10:11-12 (WEB)

Read the contrast: the priests *stand* — always working, always offering, the job never done. But Christ, having made one sacrifice "forever," *sat down*. You sit when the work is finished. The endless standing of the priests and the seated Christ tell the whole story between them: the altar could never finish; the Lamb did. This is why no Christian altar offers a repeated sacrifice for sin — there is nothing left to add to a work that is "forever." The altar pointed beyond itself, all along, to the One who would offer Himself "once for all" (Hebrews 10:10) and then sit down.

The next voice in Scripture to describe Him would make the lamb personal for the first time.

Chapter Five — The Lamb Led to Slaughter

When the lamb becomes a Person

For all the centuries of animal sacrifice, the deepest shift comes when a prophet, seven hundred years before the cross, describes the coming sacrifice not as a beast but as a *Person* — a Servant who suffers, by choice, for the sins of others. Isaiah 53 is so precise that many who read it for the first time assume it must have been written after the events it describes. It was not. It was sung in synagogues centuries before Calvary.

"He was pierced for our transgressions. He was crushed for our iniquities. The punishment that brought our peace was on him; and by his wounds we are healed."
— Isaiah 53:5 (WEB)

Read the prepositions: *for* our transgressions, *for* our iniquities, the punishment that brought *our* peace fell on *him*. This is substitution made personal — not an animal standing in for a household, but a Servant standing in for a world. And then the line that names the whole book:

"All we like sheep have gone astray. Everyone has turned to his own way; and Yahweh has laid on him the iniquity of us all." — Isaiah 53:6 (WEB)

That single verse has the shape of the gospel folded inside it. *We* strayed — each of us, by name, going "his own way." And *Yahweh* — not the Servant's own guilt, but the LORD Himself — *laid on him* the iniquity of us all. The straying is ours; the load is laid on Him. This is not God venting wrath on a random victim; it is God Himself providing and laying our sin on a willing Substitute.

"As a lamb that is led to the slaughter"

And then Isaiah reaches for the very image this book has been tracing since Eden:

"He was oppressed, yet when he was afflicted he didn't open his mouth. As a lamb that is led to the slaughter, and as a sheep that before its shearers is silent, so he didn't open his mouth." — Isaiah 53:7 (WEB)

A lamb led to the slaughter — silent, unresisting, going willingly. The fig-leaf covering of Eden, the firstborn of Abel's flock, the lamb Abraham promised, the Passover lamb on the door, the daily lambs morning and evening, the spotless offering, the goat that carried sin away — all of it now gathers into the figure of a suffering Servant who is Himself the Lamb, and who goes to

His death without protest, "for the joy that was set before him" (Hebrews 12:2).

The thread Philip followed

Lest anyone think this connection is a later Christian invention, the New Testament records the exact moment a man first traced Isaiah 53 to Jesus. An Ethiopian official is reading this very chapter aloud in his chariot, puzzled, when Philip joins him:

"The place in the Scripture which he was reading was this: 'He was led as a sheep to the slaughter. As a lamb before his shearer is silent, so he doesn't open his mouth'... Philip opened his mouth, and beginning from this Scripture, preached to him about Jesus." — Acts 8:32-35 (WEB)

Beginning from Isaiah's lamb, Philip "preached to him about Jesus." That is what this whole book is doing — beginning from the Lamb of the Scriptures and arriving at Jesus.

"He shall see and be satisfied"

We must not leave Isaiah 53 in the dark, for the chapter does not end at the grave. The prophet sees past the suffering to a reward — the Lamb's slaughter is not the end of His story but the means of His triumph:

"Yet it pleased Yahweh to bruise him... When you make his soul an offering for sin, he will see his offspring. He will prolong his days... He will see the result of the suffering of his soul and be satisfied." — Isaiah 53:10-11 (WEB)

"He will prolong his days" — after being "cut off out of the land of the living" (53:8), He lives again; resurrection is written into the prophecy. "He will see his offspring" — a whole family will be born through His death. And He "will be satisfied" — the agony will prove worth it. Isaiah even foretells the strange dignity of His burial: though "they made his grave with the wicked," He was "with a rich man in his death" (53:9) — fulfilled when a rich man, Joseph of Arimathea, laid Jesus in his own new tomb (Matthew 27:57-60). Seven centuries early, the prophet saw not only the wounds but the reward, not only the slaughter but the satisfaction. The Lamb led to the slaughter would rise, see His countless offspring, and be satisfied.

By the time Isaiah lays down his pen, the portrait is nearly complete. All that remains is for someone to point at a living man and say the words. And by a river called the Jordan, someone does.

Chapter Six — The Lamb and the Cup

"Behold, the Lamb of God"

John the Baptist stands at the Jordan, and Jesus walks toward him, and John says the sentence the whole Old Testament had been waiting to make possible:

"The next day, he saw Jesus coming to him, and said, 'Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!'" — John 1:29 (WEB)

He does not say "a lamb." He says "*the* Lamb of God" — the Lamb to whom every other lamb had pointed, the Lamb Abraham said God Himself would provide, the Lamb who would do what the rivers of animal blood never could. In one sentence John gathers up Eden's covering, Abel's flock, Moriah's open question, the Passover door, the daily lambs, the spotless offering, the scapegoat that carried sin away, and Isaiah's silent Servant — and lays them all on one man. *This* is the One the entire system was built to help you recognize.

But to understand what this Lamb came to do, we have to follow Him to two cups on the night before He died — and discover that the whole Bible is, in the end, the story of two cups.

The two cups of the Bible

Throughout Scripture, a cup is handed around — and it comes in two utterly different kinds.

The first is the **cup of judgment**, the cup of God's righteous wrath against sin, which the guilty must drink to the dregs:

"For in the hand of Yahweh there is a cup, with foaming wine mixed with spices. He pours it out. Indeed the wicked of the earth drink and drink it to its very dregs." — Psalm 75:8 (WEB)

"Awake, awake... Jerusalem, you who have drunk at the hand of Yahweh the cup of his wrath." — Isaiah 51:17 (WEB)

"Take this cup of the wine of wrath from my hand, and cause all the nations to whom I send you to drink it." — Jeremiah 25:15 (WEB)

This is the cup our sin had filled — the just response of a holy God to real evil. By every measure of justice, it belonged in our hands.

But there is a second cup in the Bible, and it is the opposite of the first — the **cup of salvation**, the cup of blessing, the overflowing cup of those whom God has rescued:

"You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies... My cup runs over."
— Psalm 23:5 (WEB)

"I will take the cup of salvation, and call on Yahweh's name." — Psalm 116:13 (WEB)

"The cup of blessing which we bless, isn't it a sharing of the blood of Christ?" — 1 Corinthians 10:16 (WEB)

Here is the question the whole gospel answers: *how does the cup change?* How does the cup in a sinner's hand turn from foaming wrath into overflowing salvation? The answer is the heart of this book — and it happened on one night, in two scenes.

The cup at the table

On the night before He died, Jesus took a cup at the Passover table, and gave it to His disciples with words that turned the old feast into a new covenant:

"He took the cup, gave thanks, and gave to them, saying, 'All of you drink it, for this is my blood of the new covenant, which is poured out for many for the remission of sins.'" — Matthew 26:27-28 (WEB)

He gave them the cup. The cup of blessing, the cup of the new covenant, the cup of forgiveness — placed into the hands of the very men who would, within hours, betray, deny, and abandon Him. He told them to drink salvation. But before He could place the cup of blessing in their hands, He had to take another cup into His own.

The cup in the garden

He rises from the table and goes to a garden called Gethsemane, and there the strongest man who ever lived falls on His face in anguish and prays the prayer that opens this book:

"He went forward a little, fell on his face, and prayed, saying, 'My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass away from me; nevertheless, not what I desire, but what you desire.'" — Matthew 26:39 (WEB)

People often read this as Jesus dreading the nails. The crucifixion was indeed horrific — but men far less than Jesus have faced torture and death with composure. What made the sinless

Son sweat, as it were, "great drops of blood" (Luke 22:44) was not the cup of physical pain but the *cup* — the cup of the prophets, the cup of God's judgment against the sin of the world, which He was about to drink to its dregs in our place. He, who had never known the Father's frown, was about to be "made... to be sin on our behalf" (2 Corinthians 5:21) and to drink down the wrath that cup contained.

And then He prays a second time, and the words tighten to a single, terrible point:

"My Father, if this cup can't pass away from me unless I drink it, your desire be done." — Matthew 26:42 (WEB)

Hear the shift. The first prayer asked, *can the cup pass?* The second asks the deeper question: *can the cup pass without being drunk?* And the answer, written across the cross, is **no**. The cup of judgment could not simply be set aside, poured out, ignored — for that would mean sin never mattered and justice was a fiction. The cup had to be **drunk**. The only question was who would drink it.

Why the cup did not pass

This is the moment that reveals, more clearly than almost any other, *why the Lamb was necessary at all*. Stand at Gethsemane and watch the alternatives fall away one by one:

- If humanity could have been saved by good deeds, the cup would have passed. It did not.
- If religious sincerity were enough, the cup would have passed. It did not.
- If God could simply ignore sin without dealing with it, the cup would have passed. It did not.
- If another prophet, another teacher, another way could have solved it, the cup would have passed. It did not.
- If the blood of bulls and goats could have taken away sin, the cup would have passed. It did not.

The cup did not pass. Jesus drank it. And in that refusal of the cup to pass, we learn the true depth of the human problem and the true cost of our redemption. The cross was not theatrical; Gethsemane proves it. Jesus did not approach His death lightly — He shrank from it with His whole holy being, and then, for love of us, He rose from His knees and went to drink what we could not survive.

By the next evening, having drained it to the last, He was able to say the word that the daily lambs and the endless altars had been waiting fifteen centuries to hear: "It is finished" (John

19:30). The debt was paid in full. The cup was empty.

The exchange

Now put the two scenes of that night together, and you see the gospel in a single image. At the table, Jesus *gives* His friends the cup of the new covenant — the cup of blessing, of forgiveness, of salvation. In the garden, He *accepts from the Father* the cup of wrath. And on the cross, He explains why the two scenes belong together. When Peter draws a sword to stop the arrest, Jesus says:

"The cup which the Father has given me, shall I not surely drink it?" — John 18:11 (WEB)

There it is. He could place the cup of blessing into His disciples' hands *because He was willing to take the cup of wrath into His own*. This is the deepest meaning of "the Lamb of God." He is not merely gentle, not merely innocent; He is the One who stands in the place of the guilty and drinks what belonged to them. The cup of judgment was ours. The Lamb drank it for us — so that the only cup left in our hands is the cup of salvation, running over.

The cup of salvation, now in your hand

Feel the wonder of the reversal. The cup that should have been in your hand was foaming wrath, to be drunk "to its very dregs" (Psalm 75:8). The cup now offered to you is the very opposite:

"I will take the cup of salvation, and call on Yahweh's name." — Psalm 116:13 (WEB)

"You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies... My cup runs over." — Psalm 23:5 (WEB)

A cup that *runs over* — not drained in judgment but overflowing with blessing. This is why, when Christians gather at the Lord's Table, they lift a cup and call it what Paul called it: "the cup of blessing which we bless" (1 Corinthians 10:16). Every communion cup is a celebration of the great exchange — a tangible reminder that the wrath was drunk by Another and the blessing was poured out for us. We did not earn the switch. We could not. The Lamb drained the one cup so that He could fill ours with the other.

So the question the two cups press upon every reader is simple and personal: *which cup is in your hand?* There is no third cup. Either you drink the cup of judgment yourself, to its dregs — or you receive, by trusting the Lamb, the cup of salvation He bought at the cost of draining the

first. The whole gospel is the offer to trade cups with the Lamb.

The Lamb did not come merely to show us how to live. He came to stand where we should have stood, to bear what we should have borne, and to drink the cup we could never have survived.

Chapter Seven — The Lamb Upon the Throne

The story does not end at the cross

If the Bible ended at the cross, the Lamb would be a tragedy — a good man crushed by the world's evil. But the story does not end there. Three days later the tomb is empty, and the Lamb who was slain is alive. And when the curtain is finally pulled back on heaven itself, in the last book of the Bible, the Lamb is not at the edge of the picture. He is at the dead center of it.

The apostle John weeps in his vision because no one is found worthy to open the scroll of God's purposes — until an elder tells him to look for a *Lion*. And John turns to see the Lion, and beholds instead the most arresting sight in all of Scripture:

"I saw in the middle of the throne... a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain."
— Revelation 5:6 (WEB)

A Lamb, standing — alive — yet bearing forever the marks of slaughter. The wounds are not erased; they are His glory. The sacrifice is not behind Him as an embarrassment; it is the very center of His identity and His throne. And heaven sings to Him the song reserved for God alone:

"Worthy are you... for you were killed, and bought us for God with your blood out of every tribe, language, people, and nation." — Revelation 5:9 (WEB)

The Lion who conquers as a Lamb

Do not miss what John has just shown us. He *heard* about a Lion — the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the conquering King. He *turned and saw* a slain Lamb. And the two are the same Person. This is the great paradox at the heart of the gospel and the universe:

John heard a Lion. John saw a Lamb. And heaven revealed that the Lion conquers as the Lamb.

Jesus does not triumph *in spite of* the cross; He triumphs *through* it. The world's idea of victory is the lion's roar, the crushing of enemies, the throne taken by force. God's victory is a Lamb who lays down His life and, in dying, defeats sin and death and the devil. "Having stripped the principalities and the powers, he made a show of them openly, triumphing over them in it" — the cross (Colossians 2:15). The weakness was the power. The slaughter was

the conquest.

Robes washed white in blood

From that throne flow images so striking they reverse the natural order of things. John sees a countless multitude from every nation, and is told who they are:

"These are those who came out of the great suffering. They washed their robes, and made them white in the Lamb's blood." — Revelation 7:14 (WEB)

Stop and feel the impossibility of it. Blood *stains*; it does not whiten. Yet here is the one blood in the universe that does the opposite — that takes the filthy and makes it spotless, that washes the guilty clean. The Lamb's blood does not contaminate the sinner who trusts it; it cleanses him whiter than snow. And by that same blood the redeemed do not merely escape; they *overcome*:

"They overcame him because of the Lamb's blood, and because of the word of their testimony." — Revelation 12:11 (WEB)

The wrath of the Lamb

There is a sterner image too, and we dare not soften it, for it is the other face of the cup. The same Lamb who was slain is also the rightful Judge, and those who finally refuse His mercy will face His justice. In a line meant to startle, John writes that the unrepentant will cry to the mountains:

"Fall on us, and hide us from the face of him who sits on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb! For the great day of his wrath has come; and who is able to stand?" — Revelation 6:16-17 (WEB)

The wrath of the Lamb. The phrase is deliberately jarring, and it teaches a solemn truth: the cup of judgment we met in chapter six does not simply vanish. For those who take refuge under the Lamb's blood, the cup was drunk by Another and is empty. But for those who reject the Lamb's mercy, the cup remains — for "if we sin willfully after we have received the knowledge of the truth, there remains no more a sacrifice for sins" (Hebrews 10:26). The gentlest figure in the Bible is also the One no one can finally escape. The Lamb who offers Himself as Savior will not be mocked as Judge. This is not a contradiction; it is the seriousness of love that took sin to a cross.

The Song of Moses and the Song of the Lamb

Heaven's worship gathers the whole story into one song — and notice whose two names are joined:

"They sing the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb." — Revelation 15:3 (WEB)

The song of Moses was the song of the Exodus — the rescue through the blood of the Passover lamb, the enemy drowned, the people brought out to freedom. Now it becomes the song of *the* Lamb, the greater Exodus: rescue not from Egypt but from sin, the true enemy defeated, a people from every nation brought home. Passover and Calvary are one story sung in two verses. The Lamb on the door and the Lamb on the throne are the same Lamb.

The Lamb who is the Shepherd

And then comes a reversal so tender it can bring tears. The slain Lamb, enthroned in glory, becomes the Shepherd of His people:

"For the Lamb who is in the middle of the throne will be their shepherd, and will lead them to springs of life-giving waters. God will wipe away every tear from their eyes." — Revelation 7:17 (WEB)

The Lamb is the Shepherd. The One who was led to the slaughter now leads the flock to living water. The One who laid down His life for the sheep (John 10:11) now wipes the tears from their faces with His own pierced hand. Lamb and Shepherd, sacrifice and King, the slaughtered and the sovereign — all one Person, Jesus.

Written in the Lamb's book

Revelation speaks again and again of a register kept in heaven — and it belongs to the Lamb. It is "the book of life of the Lamb who has been killed" (Revelation 13:8), and only those whose names are written in it enter the city of God: "There will in no way enter into it anything profane... but only those who are written in the Lamb's book of life" (Revelation 21:27). That the book belongs to *the slain Lamb* is the whole point — entrance into eternal life is granted not on the basis of our record but on the basis of His sacrifice. The names are written there in the Lamb's own blood.

And there is a staggering phrase attached to that book: the Lamb was "killed from the foundation of the world" (Revelation 13:8). The cross was not God's emergency response to a surprise; it was His plan from before creation. Peter says the same — Christ "was foreknown indeed before the foundation of the world" as the Lamb "without blemish" (1 Peter 1:19-20).

Before the first star was lit, before Adam drew breath, the Lamb was already provided in the heart of God. Eden's fall did not catch heaven off guard. The covering was prepared before the wound.

The Lamb is the lamp

And what is the light of that final city, where there is no more sea, no more night, no more tears? Not the sun, not the moon, not any created light:

"The city has no need for the sun or moon to shine, for the very glory of God illuminated it, and its lamp is the Lamb." — Revelation 21:23 (WEB)

"Its lamp is the Lamb." The One who began as a covering of skins in a darkened garden becomes the everlasting light of the new creation. The slaughtered Lamb is the sun that never sets over the home of the redeemed. This is the end of the bloodline — not merely forgiveness, not merely escape from judgment, but unending life in the light of the Lamb, who is Himself the glory of God made visible. The covering we could not make has become the light we will never outlive.

The throne, the feast, and the open invitation

The Bible's last pages do not end in an altar but at a wedding feast. The Lamb who was slain becomes the Bridegroom who welcomes His people home:

"Let's rejoice and be exceedingly glad... for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his wife has made herself ready... Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding supper of the Lamb." — Revelation 19:7, 9 (WEB)

And the very last vision of Scripture shows the destination of the whole bloodline — not a temple of endless sacrifice, but the unveiled presence of God, with the Lamb at the center of everything:

"I saw no temple in it, for the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb are its temple... the Lamb is its lamp." — Revelation 21:22-23 (WEB)

"He showed me a river of water of life, clear as crystal, proceeding out of the throne of God and of the Lamb." — Revelation 22:1 (WEB)

The throne of God and of the Lamb. That is where the road from Eden ends. The covering humanity could not make for itself in a garden has become a Lamb upon the throne of the universe, and the river of life flows from where He sits.

So the whole story can be told in a single breath: Abraham asked where the Lamb was. John pointed to Him at the Jordan. Jesus accepted the cup in the garden. The cross revealed the cost. The empty tomb revealed the victory. And Revelation shows the Lamb upon the throne. The Lamb was provided. The cup was drained. And now the invitation is open — to you.

Honest Questions

This teaching raises real questions, and faith is not afraid of them. Here are the ones most worth pressing.

"Isn't blood sacrifice just primitive superstition?"

It can look that way from the outside, but consider what it actually teaches. The sacrificial system was not magic — as if God could be bribed with animal blood. The Bible itself says the blood of animals "cannot take away sins" (Hebrews 10:4). The sacrifices were a divinely given *teaching system*, a centuries-long object lesson dramatizing truths the human heart keeps trying to deny: that sin is deadly serious, that guilt is real and cannot simply be wished away, that life is costly, and that mercy is possible only because God provides a substitute. Far from primitive, it is profound — a vivid, unforgettable way of saying what every conscience already half-knows. And it was always pointing beyond itself to the one Sacrifice that would make all the others unnecessary.

"Isn't it unjust for an innocent victim to be punished for the guilty?"

It would be — if the Lamb were an unwilling third party, dragged in to suffer for crimes He had nothing to do with. But the gospel's claim is the opposite on both counts. First, the Lamb is *willing*: "I lay down my life... No one takes it away from me, but I lay it down by myself" (John 10:17-18). Second, the Lamb is *not a third party*: He is God Himself, in the person of the Son. "God will provide *himself* the lamb" (Genesis 22:8); "God was in Christ reconciling the world to himself" (2 Corinthians 5:19). When the offended Judge chooses to step down from the bench and pay the penalty Himself, that is not the perversion of justice; it is the summit of love.

"Why couldn't God just forgive, without a Lamb and a cup at all?"

Because forgiveness is never free for the one who grants it; someone always absorbs the cost. If a friend wrongs you and you forgive the debt, *you* bear the loss — it does not simply evaporate. A God who "just forgave," waving sin away as if it never mattered, would not be loving but corrupt, the cosmic equivalent of a judge who lets every offender walk free. The cup had to be drunk because justice is real and sin is serious. The wonder of the gospel is not that God ignored the cup, but that He *drank it Himself* — upholding justice and extending mercy in

a single act. The cross is the only place in the universe where perfect justice and perfect mercy meet without either being compromised.

"If all this was planned, was Jesus' suffering real — or just going through the motions?"

Gethsemane is the answer. A man going through the motions does not sweat blood, does not fall on His face, does not beg three times that the cup might pass. The plan was real *and* the anguish was real; the two are not in tension. Jesus knew exactly what the cup contained — which is precisely why He dreaded it as no one else ever could, and why His "nevertheless, not what I desire, but what you desire" is the bravest sentence ever spoken. He saw the cup clearly, and drank it anyway, for love of us.

"How can one Lamb be enough for the whole world?"

Because of *who* He is. If Jesus were merely a man, His death could substitute for, at most, one other man. But the Lamb on the throne is the eternal Son of God, of infinite worth — and so His single sacrifice is of infinite value, sufficient for all who will trust it: "the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not for ours only, but also for the whole world" (1 John 2:2). This is why the daily lambs had to stop and this Lamb need never be offered again: "we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all" (Hebrews 10:10). One Lamb, once, forever enough.

"Isn't the 'wrath of the Lamb' a contradiction — how can a Lamb be wrathful?"

It sounds like one, and Revelation means it to arrest us — but it is not a contradiction; it is the seriousness of love. The Lamb is wrathful toward evil for the same reason a good father is fierce toward what would destroy his children: because He loves what evil ruins. A god who felt nothing toward cruelty, injustice, and the destruction of the innocent would not be more loving but less — he would be indifferent. The "wrath of the Lamb" is simply the truth that the gentlest One in the universe is also its rightful Judge, and that His patience, though vast, is not infinite. Crucially, the wrath falls only where the mercy is refused: the Lamb's blood is offered freely to all, and His judgment touches only those who, to the end, will not come under it. The wonder is not that the Lamb judges, but that He first bled to spare us from the judgment.

"Why does Revelation drench everything in blood and slaughter?"

Because it is telling the truth about how much our rescue cost, and refusing to let us forget it. We prefer a sanitized religion — a kindly teacher, a few good morals, no blood. But sin is not a manners problem; it is a death problem, and a death problem can only be answered by a life given. Revelation keeps the wounds visible — "a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" — precisely so that heaven's worship never drifts into sentimentality. The blood is not gratuitous; it is the receipt. It is the eternal evidence that the price was really paid, that our salvation was not cheap, that we were "bought... with your blood" (Revelation 5:9). Far from being morbid, the centrality of the blood is the deepest reassurance: the cost is settled, in full, forever, and the marks of it are now the glory of the One on the throne.

"What does this ask of me?"

The same thing the Passover asked of Israel: not merely to admire the Lamb, but to *come inside*, under the blood, through the door. It is not enough to find the story moving. The blood on the doorpost saved no one who stayed in the street. To trust the Lamb is to turn from your sin, to stop stitching fig leaves of your own goodness, and to take refuge under the covering God Himself has provided — to drink, by faith, the cup of salvation He bought with the cup of wrath He drank. "Behold, I stand at the door and knock," says the Lamb. "If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, then I will come in to him" (Revelation 3:20). The door is marked. The invitation is open. Will you come in?

Appendix — The Bloodline of Redemption

The Lamb and the Cup, station by station, across the whole Bible.

Station	Text (WEB)	What it reveals
The covering in Eden	Genesis 3:21	We cannot cover our own shame; God provides a covering through death
Abel's firstborn	Genesis 4:4	Drawing near to God is associated with an offered life
"Where is the lamb?"	Genesis 22:7-8	God Himself will provide the lamb; a substitute dies "instead of" the son
The blood on the door	Exodus 12:13	The lamb stands between judgment and the people; enter and be covered
The daily lamb	Exodus 29:38-39	The ceaseless sacrifice shows the need for a final one
The spotless offering	Leviticus 17:11; 1 Peter 1:19	Atonement is by blood (life), and the substitute must be without blemish
The sin carried away	Leviticus 16:22	Sin is both paid for and removed
The Lamb led to slaughter	Isaiah 53:5-7	The Lamb becomes a Person who bears sin willingly
"Behold, the Lamb of God"	John 1:29	The Lamb God promised has arrived to take away sin
Christ our Passover	1 Corinthians 5:7	Jesus is the Passover Lamb, sacrificed in our place
The cup at the table	Matthew 26:27-28	The cup of the new covenant — blessing given to us
The cup in the garden	Matthew 26:39, 42	The cup of wrath — taken into His own hands
"Shall I not drink it?"	John 18:11	He gives us the cup of blessing by drinking the cup of wrath
"It is finished"	John 19:30	The debt paid in full; the cup drained

Station	Text (WEB)	What it reveals
The Lamb standing as slain	Revelation 5:6, 9	The slain Lamb, alive, worshiped at the center of the throne
The Lion who conquers as a Lamb	Revelation 5:5-6	Victory comes through sacrifice, not in spite of it
Robes washed white in blood	Revelation 7:14	The blood that cleanses rather than stains
The Lamb who is Shepherd	Revelation 7:17	The slaughtered Lamb leads the flock to living water
The throne of God and the Lamb	Revelation 22:1-3	The bloodline ends at the throne; the river of life flows from the Lamb

Conclusion — The Lamb Was Provided, the Cup Was Drained

The story of salvation is the story of two cups. Humanity earned the cup of judgment. God offered the cup of salvation. And the exchange became possible because the Lamb of God drank the cup that belonged to us.

It is one unbroken thread. The covering we could not make in Eden. The lamb God promised to provide on the mountain. The blood on the door on the night of rescue. The endless lambs of the altar, morning and evening, never finishing. The Servant led silent to the slaughter. The Lamb pointed out at the Jordan. The cup accepted in the garden. The "It is finished" of the cross. The empty tomb. And, at the end of all things, the Lamb standing in the center of the throne, the Lion who conquered by being slain, the Shepherd who wipes away every tear, the Bridegroom who spreads the wedding feast.

The Bible begins with humanity needing a covering. It ends with the Lamb upon the throne. Between those two points stands a cross.

Abraham asked where the lamb was. John pointed to Him at the Jordan. Jesus accepted the cup in the garden. The cross revealed the cost. The empty tomb revealed the victory. Revelation shows the Lamb upon the throne. The Lamb was provided. The cup was drained. The invitation is now open.

Behold the Lamb of God — and come inside.

About this book

The Lamb and the Cup is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons.

To come under the blood of the Lamb, or to ask any question, visit Hope of Glory Ministry — Come to Christ, Ask Hope, or share a prayer request. The gospel is free, because the price was already paid.

"Worthy is the Lamb who has been killed to receive the power, wealth, wisdom, strength, honor, glory, and blessing!" — Revelation 5:12 (WEB)